

QTSS Celebrates 70 Years; Teacher Honoured with Lifetime Achievement Award After Five Decades of Service (Originally published by [Lianhe Zaobao](#) on 23 May 2026)



Art teacher Mr Sairi Bakiri (right), who has taught at Queenstown Secondary School for 50 years, is deeply committed to lifelong learning. While attending a digital art course, he met his instructor, Mr Jaymen Ng (left), their roles coming full circle when the teacher became the student. Mr Ng, who graduated from Queenstown Secondary School in 1981, was once one of Mr Sairi's students. (Photo by Chee Chih Yang)

At 75 years old, art teacher Mr Sairi Bakiri still remains dedicated to teaching. Some of the students in his classroom today are in fact the children of his former students. He has been teaching at Queenstown Secondary School for exactly 50 years.

On 26 January 1976, at the age of 24, he first reported for duty at the school. Back then, Queenstown Secondary School was still a technical school, training technicians and craftsmen needed during Singapore's early industrialisation years. Today, after half a century, the campus has changed significantly, with specially designed collaborative learning spaces and digital teaching tools, providing a curriculum that focuses on 21st-century competencies, as well as sustainability.

Mr Sairi said that every new batch of students brings fresh energy, novel perspectives, and new possibilities. This constant renewal has kept his passion

for teaching alive for the past 50 years.

He firmly believes that art and education have the power to change lives. “Art helps students express emotions that are difficult to put into words, and it also nurtures confidence and sensitivity, which will benefit them throughout their lives after leaving school.”

Although he is already in his seventies, Mr Sairi has never stopped learning. He has been studying the application of digital software in art and actively exploring artificial intelligence (AI) tools. Interestingly, when Mr Sairi attended a digital art course organised by the Ministry of Education, the instructor teaching digital imaging and design using Adobe Photoshop, Mr Jaymen Ng (61), was once his student.

Mr Sairi described this unique teacher-student relationship by saying, “In an unexpected twist, the teacher and student exchanged roles, yet their enduring bond remained unchanged.”

Still upholding the school’s motto of ‘Dare to Serve’, Queenstown Secondary School held the 70th Anniversary Gala Night Dinner

This connection spanning more than half a century has also become a reflection of Queenstown Secondary School’s 70-year history. Started in 1956, the school held its 70th anniversary gala night dinner on Saturday, 23 May 2026, looking back on its journey from a technical school to a mainstream school in the heartlands, and how it has built deeply connected ties with the Queenstown community over the decades.

The school has always upheld its motto, “Berani Berkhidmat” (Dare to Serve), nurturing different generations of students. The dedication of the teachers has played a crucial role in this mission. During the anniversary dinner, the school’s alumni association presented Mr Sairi with a retirement recognition award and a lifetime achievement award.

Principal Mr Sim How Chong said in an interview that the school’s 70th anniversary is not only a celebration of its history, but also an opportunity to rediscover the spirit of the school. “For students, they will realise that they are part of a much larger history; for alumni, it is a homecoming; and for the community, it shows how a heartland school can continue progressing while remaining deeply rooted in the community.”

In conjunction with the 70th anniversary celebrations, the school has

reimagined its heritage gallery and created a commemorative mural to preserve the intergenerational bonds shared by the school, its alumni, and the community.

The reimagined heritage gallery is divided into four sections, showcasing the school's major milestones over the past 70 years, stories of distinguished alumni, the contributions of former principals and veteran teachers, as well as school life experienced by different generations.

Mr Sim explained that the heritage gallery is not a static exhibition. Through historical investigation projects, students interview alumni, as well as collect stories and artefacts, as they learn about the school's history through multiple sources, contributing new content each year.



Senior Minister of State in the Prime Minister's Office and Deputy Secretary-General of the National Trades Union Congress, Mr Desmond Tan (second from left), and SUTL Group Chairman and CEO, Mr Arthur Tay (first from left), are both alumni of Queenstown Secondary School. They attended the school's 70th anniversary celebrations and visited the reimagined heritage gallery together. (Photo by Chee Chih Yang)

Senior Minister of State in the Prime Minister's Office and Deputy Secretary-General of the National Trades Union Congress, Mr Desmond Tan, was the guest of honour at Queenstown Secondary School's 70th anniversary celebration. He is also a graduate of the school.

In his speech, he mentioned that his most treasured memories from his school days were not from the classroom, but from playing sports with friends, attending concerts, studying together, and exploring new things every day.

He said that although the school has continuously evolved over the past 70

years, the values and spirits it upholds have remained unchanged. “The story of Queenstown Secondary School is also the story of Singapore, constantly changing and progressing, while remaining grounded in the values of courage, service, and mutual support. May this spirit continue to be passed down, inspiring generations of Queenstownians to bravely move forward, serve others, and help one another succeed.”

Translated by Wu Zhenyi (4 Aspire, 2026), Li Zhencheng (4 Gratitude, 2026), and Gong Yucheng (4 Aspire, 2026)